



▲ Astronomical table

This circle, showing the signs of the zodiac with the sun's chariot at the center, is based on 2nd-century Greek scholar Ptolemy's *Almagest*, the definitive work on astronomy for 1,300 years. His book on astrology, *Tetrabiblos*, was equally influential in Byzantium.

indulged in magical practices—although the link was sometimes made by later writers who may have wanted to discredit them.

The 11th-century Empress Zoë was reported to have murdered her husband Romanos III in order to marry her young lover Michael, and then used amulets and magic potions in a desperate attempt to get pregnant, according to the monk and scholar Michael Psellos. Patriarch John the Grammarian

was said to have dabbled in the occult, while nobleman Alexios Axouch was accused of consulting a *go-es* (sorcerer). Axouch was imprisoned in a monastery for life for using potions to prevent Empress Maria of Antioch having a child, but the charges may have been concocted by his enemies.

Astrology and divination

Byzantium was home to leading astrologers, such as Hephaestion in the 6th century, but astrology held an ambiguous place in the Byzantine world. Some churchmen studied it to work out the liturgical calendar, but prognostication (the study of stars to predict the future) was considered to